PAUL FERNANDEZ / REAL ESTATE ADVISORY

LOS ANGELES · ORANGE · RIVERSIDE · SAN BERNARDINO

SELLER'S GUIDE · EDITION Q1 2026

Preparing to sell in Southern California.

A clear, current look at what the data shows — and what it means for sellers across four counties.

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DATA CURRENT AS OF
Q1 2026

02 / FOREWORD

A note before we begin.

This guide is written for homeowners in Los Angeles, Orange, Riverside, and San Bernardino counties who are weighing a sale in the next twelve months. It is not a pitch, and it is not a list of reasons the market is urgent. It is a working document — current data, a few frameworks for reading that data, and a small number of decisions worth thinking through before a sign goes in the yard.

The Southern California market in 2026 looks different than it did in 2022, and different again from a year ago. Inventory is rising in most submarkets. Prices have softened year over year. Days on market have stretched in some pockets and tightened in others. None of that is good or bad on its own. What it does mean is that the questions a seller asks today are not the same questions a seller asked two years ago, and the answers have changed too.

> *Selling well starts with understanding your options.*

The pages that follow are intended to make those options legible — what the market is doing, what affects price and what does not, how the first thirty days tend to unfold, and what the closing math actually looks like. Read it in any order. Skip what does not apply.

— Paul Fernandez

03 / THE DATA

What the data is showing across Southern California.

Real estate is local. In Orange County alone, Anaheim's median is $929,136 and Irvine's is $1,751,670 — a gap of roughly $822,000, or 88 percent, between two cities sitting in the same county and the same quarter. A single "Orange County average" would describe neither submarket, and similar compression happens in every county. The eight submarkets below were chosen to show that range, two per county, rather than to stand in for a regional figure.

SUBMARKET	COUNTY	MEDIAN PRICE	MEDIAN DOM	3-MO INVENTORY	YOY PRICE
Whittier	Los Angeles	$889,496	25 days	+4.8%	−2.5%
Long Beach	Los Angeles	$995,518	35 days	+5.4%	+12.5%
Irvine	Orange	$1,751,670	41 days	+22.5%	−10.5%
Anaheim	Orange	$929,136	24 days	+19.2%	+6.2%
Corona	Riverside	$755,269	42 days	+11.2%	−7.2%
Riverside	Riverside	$710,236	34 days	+11.8%	+1.6%
Rancho Cucamonga	San Bernardino	$863,345	35 days	+10.7%	−4.3%
Ontario	San Bernardino	$662,924	41 days	+16.3%	−3.9%

Days on market correlate with price band more than with geography. Anaheim at 24 days is clearing nearly twice as fast as Irvine at 41 days — the same two Orange County submarkets whose price gap opened this section. Higher-priced inventory has been more sensitive to pricing accuracy this quarter, and the DOM column is where that sensitivity surfaces first.

The YoY column is the least uniform reading on the page. Three submarkets are up against last year — Long Beach at +12.5 percent, Anaheim at +6.2, and Riverside at +1.6 — while the other five are down, with Irvine at −10.5 setting the lower edge. The 23-point spread between Long Beach and Irvine points to a market re-sorting at the submarket level rather than moving as a single Southern California region.

Inventory is rising in every submarket on the table, which tilts the math toward buyers regardless of which side of the YoY line a city sits on.

04 / TIMING

Six signals that the timing is right.

Seasonality matters, but it is one signal among several. The question of whether to list this spring, this fall, or two years from now turns on a small set of indicators that, taken together, describe whether a given submarket is leaning toward sellers or toward buyers. Below are the six worth tracking before any sign goes in the yard.

SIGNAL	WHAT TO LOOK FOR	WHEN IT FAVORS SELLING
Median price trajectory in your submarket	Three-month and twelve-month direction of median sold price in your zip and product type	When the curve is flat or rising and recent comps support the price band you need
Days-on-market trend	Whether DOM is compressing or stretching quarter over quarter	When DOM is compressing — homes are clearing faster, signaling absorbed demand
Inventory supply (months of supply)	Total active listings divided by monthly closed sales	When supply is under four months in your submarket, the math tilts toward sellers
Mortgage rate environment	The current thirty-year fixed rate and its three-month direction	When rates are flat or falling — buyer affordability improves and showing traffic rises
Season — spring vs fall vs holiday window	Calendar timing relative to peak buyer activity in your county	Spring (March–May) and early fall (September–October) tend to draw the broadest buyer pools
Personal life event	Downsizing, relocation, estate, or simultaneous move on a defined timeline	When the move is required, not optional — clarity on timing outweighs market timing

The signals do not always agree. A submarket can show rising inventory and falling rates in the same quarter. A seller can be in a perfect personal window during an imperfect macro one. The point of the table is not to score the market — it is to make the inputs visible so the decision is conscious.

Sometimes the right answer is to wait. Two situations point that direction more clearly than others. The first is when the home is not yet prepared — major deferred maintenance, an outdated systems issue, or a layout problem that staging will not solve. Listing before the home is ready almost always costs more in price erosion than the preparation would have cost in time. The second is when a recent comparable sale in the immediate neighborhood missed badly on price. A single weak comp can drag the appraisal on a sale closing thirty days later. Waiting one quarter for that comp to age out is often worth more than the carrying cost of the wait.

05 / PRICING

What moves market value, and what doesn't.

No amount of marketing can sell an overpriced home. The math on this is straightforward. A buyer comparing three homes in the same price band will arrive at the one that prices to the comps, regardless of which has the prettier brochure. Below is the honest division between what the market responds to and what it does not.

FACTORS THAT INFLUENCE MARKET VALUE	FACTORS WITH LITTLE OR NO INFLUENCE
Supply and demand in your immediate submarket	The price originally paid for the house
Broader economic conditions and rate environment	The net proceeds the seller would like to clear at closing
Asking and selling prices of competing homes	Improvements made over the years (recouped at roughly 60% on average)
The condition of the home today	An appraisal from an unfamiliar lender's appraiser
Buyer perception — staging, photography, listing copy	An agent's promise of a price they cannot defend

The left-hand column is what the market is actually pricing. The right-hand column is what sellers, understandably, wish the market were pricing. The gap between the two is where most overpricing decisions live.

Two notes on the left column worth pulling out. Condition matters in absolute terms, not relative terms. A buyer is not comparing this home to what it looked like five years ago — they are comparing it to the other home they toured this weekend. And buyer perception, while it sounds soft, is measurable: listings with strong photography and accurate copy generate more first-week showings, and first-week showings correlate strongly with sale price.

The right-hand column is harder to internalize because it is personal. None of those numbers feel small to the seller. They simply do not move buyers.

The price the market sets and the price the seller wants are two different numbers. Selling well begins with knowing which one the listing reflects.

06 / PREPARATION

Preparing the home: what actually moves price.

There is a recurring misalignment between what sellers feel they should do before listing and what the market actually rewards. The instinct is to remodel, upgrade, premiumize. The market, in most cases, is asking for something quieter — cleanliness, light, accurate pricing, and a faithful presentation of the home as it actually is. Below is a side-by-side reading of the gap.

WHAT SELLERS THINK MATTERS	WHAT ACTUALLY MOVES PRICE
Remodel the kitchen	Deep clean, declutter, paint
Hire a stager	Stage the listing photos
Fix every cosmetic flaw	Fix structural and safety issues only
List at premium for finishes	Price for the comp band
Wait for spring	List when the home is prepared

Kitchen remodels are the most common overshoot. A full remodel before listing rarely returns its cost — recovery sits closer to sixty percent on average across the four counties. The exception is when the existing kitchen has a fatal flaw a buyer cannot move past: severely outdated cabinetry combined with damaged flooring, or a layout that fails the home's price band. Short of that, paint, hardware, and cleanliness do most of the work.

Staging is a real lever, but the place it pays back is in the photographs, not the in-person showing. Buyers form their first impression on a screen days before they walk in. The listing photo set is where staging earns its keep. Empty homes that are well photographed almost always outperform empty homes that are not.

Cosmetic punch lists tend to grow. Most buyers expect — and price into their offers — that small cosmetic issues exist. The fixes that matter are the ones that affect safety, function, or inspection: roof, HVAC, plumbing, electrical, anything that will surface in a buyer's report. Cosmetic work past that point is mostly a tax on the seller's calendar.

On timing: the home being prepared matters more than the calendar month. A home listed in March that is not ready will be outperformed by the same home listed in October that is.

The goal is clarity before you decide.

07 / THE ARC

The 30-day arc.

Thirty days is the rough average from listing to contract across well-priced, well-prepared homes in the four counties this quarter. It is an average, not a guarantee. A home priced into the wrong band, or listed before it is ready, can sit for sixty or ninety. A home in a tight submarket with a clean presentation can clear in ten. The structure below is what the average month looks like.

WEEK	WHAT HAPPENS	WHAT THE SELLER DOES
Week 1 DAYS 1–7	Pre-list: comparative market analysis, prep walkthrough, photography prep, listing agreement signed	Finalize price band, complete any last prep, confirm the listing copy
Week 2 DAYS 8–14	Go-live: photos shot, MLS goes live, marketing distributes, first showings begin	Vacate for showings, monitor early feedback, hold the price
Week 3 DAYS 15–21	Active market: open houses, offer review, negotiation	Review offers as a package — price, terms, financing, contingencies
Week 4 DAYS 22–30	Under contract: inspections, appraisal, contingency removals	Respond promptly to requests, hold contingency timelines, stay out of the buyer's process where possible

Two things are worth flagging inside this arc.

The first is that early feedback is the most honest feedback. The first ten showings tell the most accurate story about whether the listing is priced correctly. If the showings come and the offers do not, the price is the conversation. If the showings do not come at all, the photos or the price band is the conversation. The shape of the first week is more predictive than the second or third.

The second is that the appraisal and inspection windows in Week 4 are where deals most often stall. A clean presentation in Week 1 reduces the noise in Week 4.

Twenty-five days is the average. Yours may move faster.

08 / THE MATH

Closing costs in plain numbers.

Sellers tend to anchor on list price. The number that actually matters is the net — what is left in the account after commissions, transfer taxes, title, escrow, prorations, and any concessions negotiated with the buyer. Below is a rough map of what closing costs look like across five common Southern California price tiers.

SALE PRICE	ESTIMATED SELLER CLOSING COSTS	NOTES
$500,000	$40,000–$45,000	Standard 5–6% commission plus transfer tax plus title and escrow
$750,000	$60,000–$67,500	Same structure, larger transfer tax base
$1,000,000	$80,000–$90,000	County transfer tax tier change applies in some areas
$1,500,000	$120,000–$135,000	Documentary transfer tax variances by city
$2,000,000	$160,000–$180,000	Plus the Los Angeles City "Mansion Tax" (Measure ULA) if the property sits within city limits

Commissions are negotiable and structured per transaction. The 5–6% range above reflects the common total across the four counties, split between the listing side and the buyer's side. Both halves come out of the seller's proceeds at closing.

Transfer taxes vary by city. The county base rate is consistent, but several cities — Los Angeles, Santa Monica, Culver City, Pomona — add city-level documentary transfer tax that can change the math materially. Within Los Angeles city limits, sales above the Measure ULA threshold carry an additional transfer tax that scales with price.

Concessions, when negotiated, also come out of the net. A buyer's request for a $10,000 credit toward closing costs functions as a $10,000 reduction in net proceeds, regardless of how the contract is written.

Net proceeds are the number that matters. The list price is the start of the math, not the end of it.

09 / QUESTIONS

Two questions to ask before you list.

Most listing decisions come down to two questions that are easier to ask than to answer. They are worth sitting with before the agreement is signed.

1. If you had to sell in 30 days, what would you do differently?

The answer to this question is a punch list. It surfaces the prep that has been deferred, the rooms that need attention, the conversation with the cleaner or the painter or the handyman that has been on the calendar for six months. If the list is short, the home is closer to ready than it feels. If the list is long, the timing question may already be answered — preparation comes first, then market entry.

2. What number would let you walk away comfortably — and is that number defensible against the comps?

Sellers often have a number in mind before the conversation starts. That is healthy. What matters is whether the number can be defended by recent comparable sales in the immediate submarket. A defensible number is one a thoughtful appraiser, a thoughtful buyer's agent, and a thoughtful buyer would all arrive at independently. If the number requires three exceptional outcomes in a row to be reached, it is not yet a market number — it is a wish.

The goal is clarity before you decide.

When you're ready.

There are three quiet paths forward from here. None of them require a decision today.

01 **Schedule a 30-minute consultation.**

A short, no-pressure conversation about the home, the submarket, and the timing question. Useful when the next step is not yet clear.

02 **Request a free home valuation.**

A current comparative market analysis prepared for the property, drawing on the same data this guide is built from. Useful when the next step is a number.

03 **Read recent market analysis at soldwithpaul.com/blog.**

Quarterly reads of the four-county market, written in the same register as this guide. Useful when the next step is more reading.

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